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ILLUSTRATION: R. RAJESH

DAVID ATTENBOROUGH WHERE THE WILD FOUND ITS VOICE

The British broadcaster and natural historian marks his 100th birthday after chronicling Earth's breathtaking beauty and fragile fate for generations — always urging humanity to act decisively and protect the planet's future

Shekar Dattatri

The year was 1991, and I was on my first visit to the U.K. As I presented my passport to the immigration officer at London's Heathrow Airport, my chest tightened with apprehension. Getting the visa had been stressful, I hoped my entry wouldn't be.

The officer stared at his computer screen for an uncomfortably long time before asking, "What's the purpose of your visit?" When I explained that I was a wildlife filmmaker planning to spend six months in the country to learn advanced techniques, his impassive face broke into an appreciative smile. "Ah, you want to follow in the footsteps of our Sir David!" With that, I was waved through the gate with a cheery "Welcome to the U.K.".

Admiration for David Attenborough runs deep in British society. Over a television career spanning more than seven decades, he has been a trusted guide to the animal kingdom for generations of Britons, who cherish him as a national treasure. Often hailed as the 'world's greatest broadcaster', Attenborough became a global icon as television spread to the farthest corners of the world.

But all this might never have come to pass. When Attenborough joined

the BBC as a 26-year-old natural sciences graduate in 1952, he was initially barred from appearing on camera because a boss felt his teeth were "too big". However, when the presenter of the 1954 BBC series *Zoo Quest* had to step down unexpectedly due to illness, the new head of the 'talks' department decided that young Attenborough would host the show. The rest, as they say, is history.

A new perspective

My introduction to Attenborough's documentaries began with the landmark 1979 television series *Life on Earth*. With the world as its canvas, the 13-episode show brought natural history to the screen like never before, setting a benchmark for films in this genre. For the first time, we saw sights such as a flying frog's spectacular gliding ability in slow motion, and a sword-billed hummingbird's hovering precision as it reached deep into a *Datura* flower to extract the nectar within.

But the most iconic moment came in episode 12, 'Life in the Trees'. In the sequence shot in Rwanda, we see Attenborough crawling on all fours towards a group of wild gorillas, making soft "belch vocalisations" to signal friendly intentions. After a while, he is sandwiched between a female and her two playful adolescents. As the mother looks deeply into his eyes

from just inches away, Attenborough turns towards the camera and, in a half-whisper heard around the world, tells us that "there is more meaning and mutual understanding in exchanging a glance with a gorilla than with any other animal I know".

Not only did this endearing scene dispel the myth that gorillas were 'bloodthirsty' creatures, but it also cemented Attenborough's reputation as an unflappable presenter, deeply empathetic towards the natural world. In an interview decades later, he recalled this encounter with the mountain gorillas as "one of the most privileged moments of my life".

The enthusiastic public reception for *Life on Earth* led to dozens of other series — featuring Attenborough as presenter or narrator, or both — each more spectacular than the last, thanks to remarkable advances in imaging technology.

Apart from these, there have also been numerous standalone documentaries, including two of my favourites — *Attenborough in Paradise* (1996), which transports us to New Guinea and introduces us to a variety of birds of paradise, and *The Amber Time Machine* (2004), in which Attenborough examines the feasibility of extracting DNA from insects trapped in amber millions of years ago. This idea was popularised in Steven Spielberg's 1993 sci-fi

blockbuster *Jurassic Park*, which, incidentally, starred Attenborough's elder brother, Richard.

Team Planet Earth

As Attenborough looks back on his 100 fruitful years on this planet, he can take great satisfaction in his unparalleled body of work, which has educated and inspired hundreds of millions around the world and documented the richness of our beautiful yet beleaguered planet for posterity.

But how could anyone accomplish all this in a single lifetime, even a long one? As Attenborough has explained in public appearances and TV interviews, he does not produce or shoot these films himself. Behind his on-screen presence are teams of highly skilled and dedicated cinematographers who toil for weeks or months to capture nature's intricate wonders. And behind them is a team of researchers, producers, writers and editors.

However, one thing is certain: no one else has travelled the globe as extensively, experienced as many ecosystems, or observed as many species as Attenborough. Through the legion of documentary films he's been involved in and the numerous books he's authored, he has witnessed the impact our species has had on the natural

world for longer, and perhaps with a keener eye, than anyone else. What an eventful 100 years he has lived through.

When he entered the world on May 8, 1926, the global population was a mere 2 billion, compared with 8 billion today. Forests covered roughly half the world's land area, compared with about one-third now. Atmospheric carbon dioxide concentration has risen from about 300 parts per million to 425 parts per million, wreaking havoc on the world's climate. All this and more are poignantly captured in Attenborough's 2020 documentary, *A Life on Our Planet: My Witness Statement and a Vision for the Future*. It should be compulsory viewing for everyone.

However, all the awareness generated by his work will be in vain if we sit back and allow our planet's continued destruction. The best gift we can give Attenborough on his 100th birthday is to pledge, each in our own way, to heal the wounds we've inflicted on the Earth. Although nature is dying by a thousand cuts every day, it still retains a fragile resilience. To pull back from the precipice, we must shed our customary indifference and urgently unite as citizens of Planet Earth.

The writer is a wildlife and conservation filmmaker.



When my son was four or five, he took to wildlife instinctively. He started watching Attenborough's documentaries on television, and we all got hooked. We bought his books and DVDs, and they catalysed our thinking about the natural world, the diversity of species, and the human impact on wildlife. Attenborough's work foregrounds issues such as the climate crisis and the 'sixth extinction'. If we want to continue seeing the magic of the wild unfold, as Attenborough did, our immediate focus must be restraint [when it comes to future land use] and restoration. If we don't want his videos to become archaeological artifacts, we need to change course, and fast.

ANITA MANI
Founder of Indian Pitta, a book imprint with Juggernaut



David Attenborough was a part of Indira Gandhi's circle of naturalists. In 2019, in his acceptance speech on winning the Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament and Development, he recalled a conversation with her in the early 1960s. Attenborough had driven her to Birmingham, where they discussed how television could be used for education and public communication. If Attenborough's century was about seeing the natural world, the coming century is about saving it. That requires mainstreaming his ideas in political discourse. Those who stand by his ideas must also oppose projects such as the ecologically disastrous Great Nicobar Project.

JAIRAM RAMESH
Rajya Sabha MP and former Union Minister for Environment and Forests

SHORTLISTED FOR THE WOMEN'S PRIZE
FOR FICTION 2026

Catch me if you can

Through letters to friends and others, the 73-year-old protagonist weaves a thrilling yet tender narrative

GETTY IMAGES

Cris

Prejudices are hard to shed, especially when you have an overactive imagination. As soon as you hear about the 73-year-old protagonist of a new epistolary novel, you picture a gentle old woman sipping her tea, writing letters every morning. But Sybil Van Antwerp in *The Correspondent* by Virginia Evans quickly dismantles that image.

Sybil is not your adorable granny from *Looney Toons*. She is a stickler for the rules, stubborn to the point of exasperation, and at times, even unlikeable. Yet, that is what makes her compellingly human. The novel is a frontrunner for this year's Women's Prize for Fiction, the winner of which will be announced on June 11.

Hidden in plain sight

As you dive into Sybil's world, you get caught up in the excitement of the world of letters – both handwritten missives and emails. Obvious questions such as whether she is lonely, strike you much later because her life seems full of connections, even if few people share her physical space.

The tone remains consistent, whether Sybil writes to her oldest friend Rosalie, her brother Felix or her kindly neighbour Theodore. She opens up only to close ones, but



does not hold herself back even with newcomers. It's funny how, as a reader, you begin to look for character even in a letter, in every exclamation and endearment.

But again, you will be wrong to judge her too soon. Sybil can seem like a distant mother, especially to the one daughter who writes back, yet her letters brim with detail – books read, thoughts half-formed, fragments of memory. Still, she remains elusive. Evans is gentle with her, unfolding the layers of a woman who has buried too much within.

The introvert's life

Hints of Sybil's past – a long career in law alongside a respected judge – offer only glimpses into her life. She speaks fondly of the judge, who passes away at the beginning of the book, and herein lies the limitation of the epistolary



The Correspondent
Virginia Evans
Michael Joseph
₹899

form. You cannot be a witness to a live event. For weeks, Sybil talks about the speech she has to make at the funeral but you never get to partake in the moment. You will have to wait for her report in the next letter.

Not that it takes away from your enjoyment of this beautifully arranged novel. Evans builds her story with patience,

revealing a new layer of Sybil with every carefully-curated mail.

Relationships may not be Sybil's strong suit, but she has her ways of reaching out. She can easily connect to a brilliant but socially awkward teenager. She makes friends with a customer care executive, but is wary of getting close to men who show an interest in her. Sybil confides more than once that it is easier for her to write than to have a conversation.

Quite effortlessly, Evans shapes *The Correspondent* into both a slow burn mystery and a warm, witty novel. Even when you don't agree with Sybil, you find yourself reaching out to her, to reassure her that it's alright, Sybil.

The Kerala-based feature writer explores culture, cinema, history and literature.

Inheritance of cruelty

This powerful debut explores how faith, desire and violence shape intimate family lives

Saurabh Sharma

Sam, their dog, “fell like a log” when Priscilla, one of the two central protagonists and narrators of the Women's Prize for Fiction-shortlisted novel, *Dominion*, “released the clasp on his leash”. Noticing her pastor husband “staring at us from his study”, the heinousness of the crime dawns on her. He has brutally killed the dog.

Mississippi-born author Addie E. Citchens then draws readers into Priscilla's mind: “I knew and expected certain things from him, for he was nothing but a man, but that kind of cruelty I didn't know how to address or reconcile. Now I only went into his bedroom to change his sheets.” The knowledge at play here is two-fold: of the nature of men, and of the nature of a husband. But there's also a liminal submission here: Priscilla's place in the larger scheme of things. What does one do with knowledge that cannot be acted upon, when one's circumstances afford no real agency?

In this stellar debut, Citchens not only manages to demonstrate this effect, but also drives a searing narrative of parenthood, sisterhood, and the intersectionality of



Dominion
Addie E. Citchens
Farrar Straus & Giroux
₹2,585

identity, staging the scenes that unfold around the Seven Seals M.B. Church, where Priscilla's husband, Rev. Sabre Winfrey, Jr., presides as pastor.

Together, they have five sons – twins, Trey and Moshe, Mack, Ivy and Emanuel. The last, the youngest, is also called Manny or Wonderboy. He's desired by everyone, and holds a special place in his mother's heart, who, despite her beauty, is glanced at awkwardly, for she has a “small frame and bad hip”. She is grateful that Manny “looked like the best of both of them”. However, by her own admission, wouldn't Manny then carry some of his father's cruelty too?

The ‘bright’ man

Manny's talents are many, but there's also a halo around him, of his unpredictability in the face of events. Readers hardened by their life experiences would know instinctively that beneath this beauty there's an evil at play, which materialises when they meet the other narrator – a young, orphaned girl, Diamond, who has known hunger like none of the Winfreys. But, the hunger for love is of a different kind. It misinforms your judgment like nothing else. Though she's adopted by a widow, Maggie, and is in touch with her siblings, there's a sadness she's consumed by. Something, perhaps, her mother gifted her: “a lifetime of isolation, of wanting so bad that it hurts”.

What happens when a prodigious young man is in a relationship with a young girl who can be easily ostracised, or is even believed to bring ill luck to the bright boy? Wasn't it Judge Edward Cowart who referred to the serial killer Ted Bundy as a “bright young man”? Society often seems more concerned with the waste of a talented man than with the lives he destroys in the process. And isn't it the mother who is ultimately blamed for raising such a son?

In a man's world, it is still the man who is

labelled “bright”, no matter how much darkness he leaves in his wake.

Defining identity

Even though rock solid, if that were the arc of the story, it would still feel predictable – requiring the author's command over language to carry it forward. Demonstrating her craft, Citchens complicates this trajectory instead, offering sexuality as a force to be reckoned with. She binds it with shame – an overwhelming emotion that can consume if left unprocessed, or compel one towards extraordinary, often irredeemable, acts.

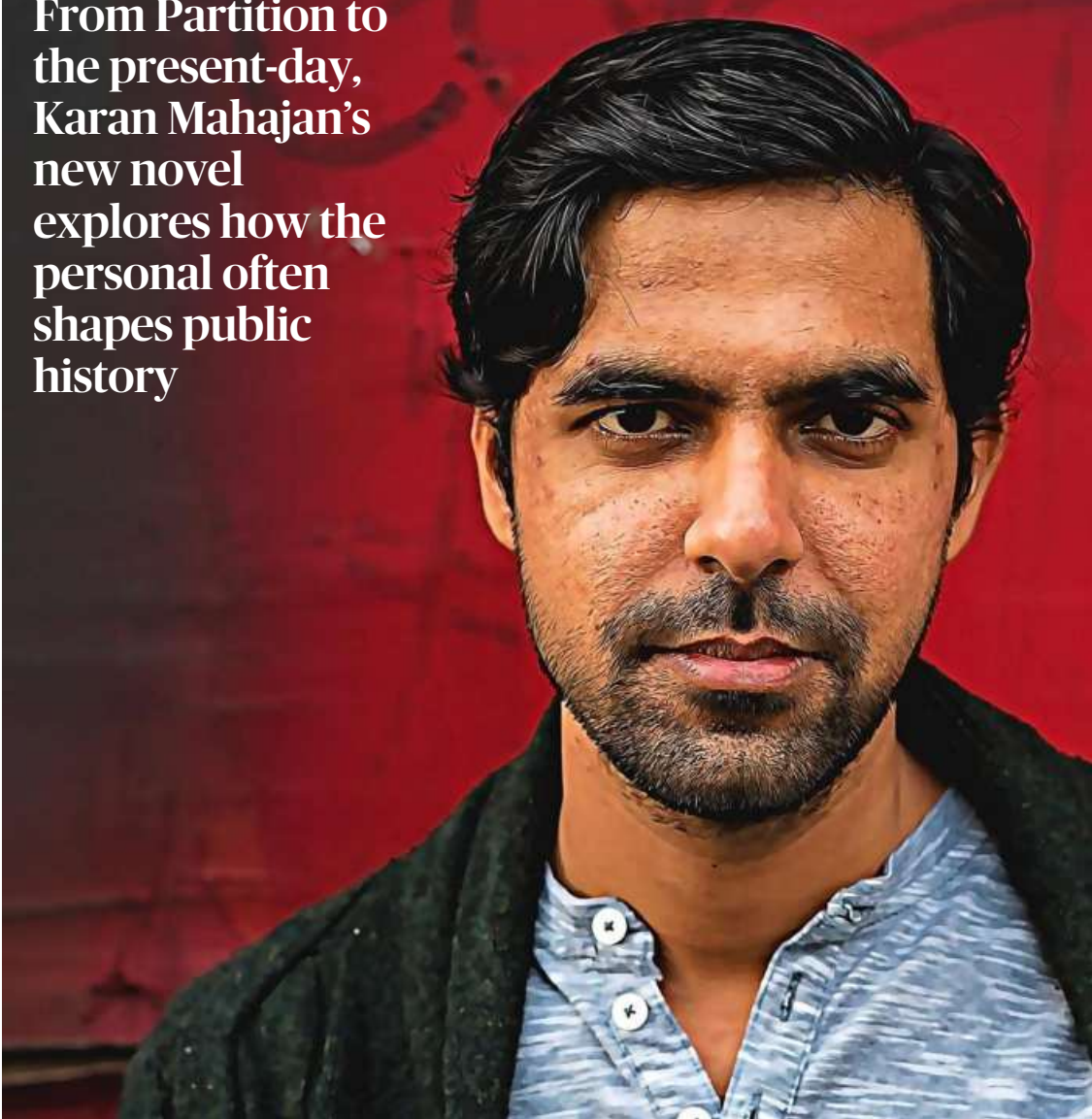
Shifting between the perspectives of Priscilla and Diamond as they witness the turbulent aftermath of Manny's actions within a structure shaped by Sabre's “morning messages” at the church, and using deftly placed third-person narrative interruptions, *Dominion* emerges as an assured debut. It restores faith in the power of language – and in the act of owning one's story – suggesting that we are not defined solely by what has happened to us, but by what we choose to carry forward.

The reviewer is a Delhi-based queer writer and culture critic.

IN CONVERSATION

POLITICS OF MEMORY

From Partition to the present-day, Karan Mahajan's new novel explores how the personal often shapes public history



Kanika Sharma

There is something prismatic about remembering. In the mind's eye, the past refracts, and history stops feeling inevitable. In his latest novel, *The Complex* (HarperCollins), Karan Mahajan achieves a similar effect, following a post-Partition Punjabi joint family through the upheavals of the 1980s and ‘90s – from the Mandal Commission to the rise of Hindutva politics. As they navigate these shifts, they emerge as both causes and consequences of a nation in churn.

Now based in the U.S., Mahajan returns to the Delhi of his childhood, where joint families jostled for space and intimacy within a single housing complex. Through figures like the patriarch S.P. Chopra and the immigrants Gita and Sachin Chopra, set against the opportunistic Laxman Chopra, the author traces how patriarchy, sexual and religious violence, and politics shape lives across generations. These concerns also run through his earlier works, *Family Planning* (2008) and *The Association of Small Bombs* (2016), revealing a sustained interest in the inseparability of the personal and the political.

In this conversation, Mahajan reflects on memory, migration and the emotional impulses intersecting private lives and public histories. Edited excerpts:

Question: How autobiographical is *The Complex*?

Answer: If there's an autobiographical root for the novel, it lies in emotion. As an immigrant, I have felt suspended between the U.S. and India. I came for college and assumed I would return to India. I kept telling myself that story for years, even as it became more and more untrue.

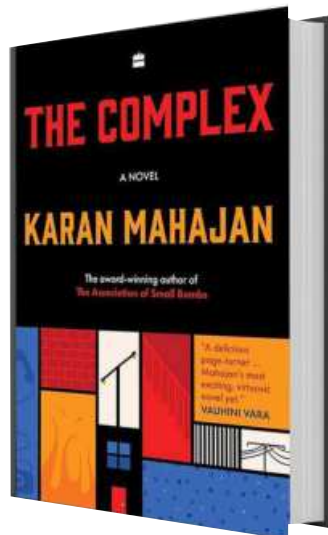
Thus, the novel begins with Gita Chopra, a woman in her late 20s who goes to the U.S. in the late 1970s to be with her husband and is in denial about where they are. The system of meaning that she could have developed in the new country, to counter the system of meaning we all have, by default, in the place we come from, never develops in the U.S. She starts looking back to India and thinks of moving back. But, on a

trip to India, she is sexually assaulted by a relative. Suddenly, this space of family in Delhi also starts becoming unsafe. And so, she feels at home nowhere.

Q: Given that the novel is based on historical events, what research did you undertake?

A: I research my novels almost journalistically. I go out into the world and talk to as many people as possible. I make a huge number of notes, go through archives, and read newspaper reports. It's just so that I can enter that era myself.

Take the Mandal Commission protests in 1990. I was six and remember school being closed for a few weeks. I didn't really understand its history, though. I talked to many fellow writers and editors in Delhi, especially those who were in college at the time. Many, left-leaning now, had participated in the protests. Someone described the



atmosphere as a college party. Only in retrospect did they think, ‘Oh, I'm embarrassed, I didn't understand my privilege’. That became useful because it allowed me to enter the event sideways as opposed to coming at it, let's say, from [then prime minister] V.P. Singh's perspective or of documented history.

Q: Why do so many characters have a double consciousness as they become different people in different situations?

A: I'm fascinated by how one person's consciousness is constantly mediated and invaded by others'. That's partly why the novel jumps from one character's head to another, sometimes in the space of a sentence or a paragraph. I think that was how my mind was

formed, too.

In a country like India, people simultaneously occupy different eras and social mores. You might have a more open and Westernised personality with your friends, and an entirely different one with your relatives. That constant navigation is really interesting.

On a similar note, this is why we never know a politician's inner motivations. They speak along party lines, but the true wound or source of that will to power is hardly known.

Q: In the novel, Laxman is a sexual predator and, eventually, a right-wing politician. This is a conjunction that is becoming disturbingly familiar. Was that intentional?

A: It's not a coincidence. Any kind of fiction with a historical bent gets inflected with the concerns of the present. One way of writing about any kind of right-wing ideology is that – if you have an ancestor or a parent who is “great” – you're constantly shadowed by that legacy, and you wish to recapture it. And of course, that leads to a backward-looking ideology. Laxman is an exaggeration of that, because he's the biggest loser in the family and wants to be the greatest man, on a par with his father. Obviously, something disastrous will come of that.

Moreover, right-wing movements strongly support the idea of patriarchy. Sexual control and sexual violence are by-products of that. But it's not that left-wing movements are innocent either. You have all these disturbing revelations coming out about Cesar Chavez in the U.S. right now. He was a great organiser of agricultural workers.

I think that Trump, especially, is a good example of what I'm talking about. People thought that the revelations about him allegedly being a rapist were going to disqualify him, but in fact they made him seem more attractive to certain people in his party and people who supported him because they showed his willingness to exert masculine power and privilege. Such behaviour is a feature, not a bug, of certain movements.

The interviewer is a freelance journalist with bylines in leading international and Indian publications.

Kerala’s many contradictions

In a collection of essays, civil servants write on governance in a State known for sharp contrasts

Uma Mahadevan-Dasgupta

God’s own country,” “India’s miracle State,” and “the Kerala model” are phrases that capture the affection and admiration with which the small, emerald-green State of Kerala is regarded. It is this rich, layered perspective that the essays in *The Kerala Club: Keepers of the Flame* set out to explore.

Nevertheless, it is worth recalling the British economist Joan Robinson’s words about India – that whatever you can rightly say about the country, the opposite is also true. Kerala, too, is a State of contradictions. It elected a Communist-led government led by E.M.S. Namboodiripad in 1957, just a decade after India had become free of British colonial rule. Long recognised as an outlier for its excellent literacy, health, and human development indicators, Kerala has never regarded income growth as the only measure of development. It is also a leader in democratic decentralisation, with widely recognised achievements, particularly after the “big bang” devolution of the 1990s. Panchayat ward members help residents with everything from birth certificates to toilets, to even, as in Lijo Jose Pellisserry’s film *Ee Ma Yau*, looking for a burial ground. In Jeo Baby’s film *Kaathal – The Core*, Mammootty’s character stands for election as a panchayat member. Active elected local bodies are not only reflected in popular culture but are part of daily life in Kerala – and thus a major reason why the State, through its public hospitals, anganwadis, and schools, succeeds in delivering quality childcare, education, and health services.

Yet, concerns remain. For a State with a history of a matrilineal social structure and powerful reformist movements, Kerala remains a patriarchal society. The dowry system is entrenched across communities. Alcoholism is a continuing issue. The recorded number of suicides is among the highest in India.

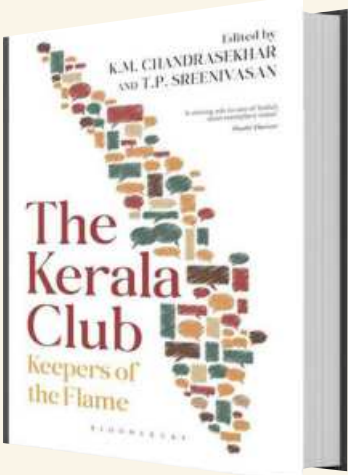
The Kerala Club is a collection of 29 essays by civil servants – some for whom Kerala was always home, and some who made it their home. As Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan points out in his foreword, India’s non-partisan civil service has played a crucial role in maintaining the nation’s democratic constitutional order. After a stint of training in Mussoorie, young recruits are sent to different State cadres where they spend the formative years of their public service. As reflected in these essays, they grow to engage deeply with their new home States.

Editors K.M. Chandrasekhar and T.P. Sreenivasan have put together a thoughtful and readable set of essays about aspects of public administration, development, and local self-governance in Kerala. From

colonial administrative practices to migrant “guest” workers, Kerala’s white revolution in dairy, and the 7,000-plus Kudumbashree women who won the local body elections of December 2020, this collection presents an insightful look at the State by some who have served it and others who have regarded it with affection, if from more distant locations, whether in Assam or Cambodia.

While consistently readable, the essays vary in depth and analytical insight. One of the most compelling essays is Surendra Kumar’s narrative, written in the first person, about Ramachandran, an elephant born wild in Assam, cared for in Bihar, and after the death of his beloved human caregiver, transported to Kerala. “My eyes welled up, but no one noticed.” This deeply felt essay reframes the collection as a meditation on displacement, care, belonging, and conflict in the world today.

One gap in the book is the lack of women’s perspectives. Except for two essays – one by K.B. Valsala Kumari on engendering governance and the other by B. Sandhya on community policing



The Kerala Club: Keepers of the Flame
Ed. K.M. Chandrasekhar, T.P. Sreenivasan
Bloomsbury
₹799

– the rest are by male authors. In a State celebrated for its social development, this imbalance is striking. It is worth recalling that the first woman to join the IAS, the trailblazing Anna Rajam George, was from Pathanamthitta in Kerala. She had a stellar career, including being the first woman to serve as Secretary to the Government of India.

The many anecdotes in this book are engaging, such as Shivshankar Menon’s account of being pushed out of the train window as a child in Ottapalam railway station. With its variety of recollections and reflections, *The Kerala Club* captures the lived texture of governance in a beautiful, complex, and endlessly fascinating State.

The reviewer is in the IAS



UNDERSTANDING THE BJP’S RISE IN BENGAL

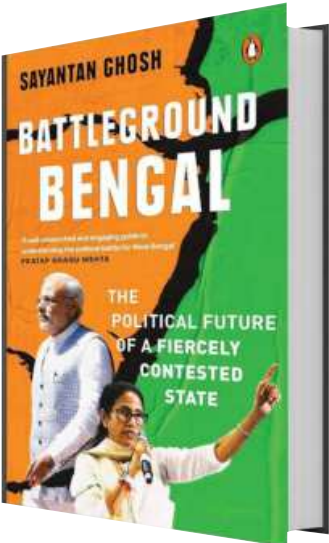
Sayantan Ghosh’s book is timely and accessible, but is more focused on the present than on deeper historical context

Sobhana K. Nair

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At a macro level, every election begins to resemble the last, high on rhetoric and low on nuance. Yet it is in the micro-details – calculations at the local level, the remembered alliances, the accretions of habit and resentment – that each election acquires its distinct character. Sayantan Ghosh’s *Battleground Bengal: The Political Future of a Fiercely Contested State* arrives at such a moment, offering readers a way to parse the granularity that is so often flattened by headline-driven political commentary.

Ghosh opens the book by tracing the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)’s rise as Bengal’s principal Opposition force, a trajectory that culminated in its electoral victory last week. As Ghosh reminds us, the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the BJP were, in fact, once allies. In the 1998 Lok Sabha elections, the TMC contested as part of the



Battleground Bengal: The Political Future of a Fiercely Contested State
Sayantan Ghosh
Penguin
₹699

National Democratic Alliance and won seven seats from West Bengal. That alliance gave the BJP legitimacy and visibility in a State where it had long struggled to find political footing. The

paradox of West Bengal, Ghosh suggests, lies partly in these remembered accommodations, even as present-day politics is conducted as war.

To understand the BJP’s present strength in the State, Ghosh argues, it is necessary to return to the period between 2014 and 2016, when the party decisively shifted from a largely non-Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) leadership to one more firmly aligned with the Sangh Parivar. The RSS expanded its organisational presence as the BJP’s electoral profile grew. Yet, this growth has not followed a straight line. The BJP’s ascent in West Bengal, as Ghosh puts it, has rested on a complex interplay of identity and ideology, which has enabled rapid expansion but also carries within it the seeds of future constraint.

What brought the BJP this far may also prove its most formidable roadblock. The party’s preference for a standardised Hindutva template has often sat uneasily with Bengal’s regional idiom. This tension surfaced even on the

campaign trail, where Prime Minister Narendra Modi switched from invoking “Jai Shri Ram” to “Jai Ma Kali.” Unlike its principal adversary, the BJP lacks a comparable mass leader to Mamata Banerjee, a gap the party has attempted to bridge through repeated leadership experiments. Ghosh traces these attempts in detail, showing how the Bengal BJP has become an uneasy amalgam of long-time workers and recent defectors from the TMC.

The veterans who held the party together when it was little more than a marginal player have increasingly been eclipsed by a newer cadre, many of whom arrived with organisational, ideological, and personal baggage. The result, Ghosh suggests, is a party that is still negotiating its own internal hierarchies.

One of *Battleground Bengal*’s strengths is its accessibility. The prose is unforced, the argument carried lightly. Ghosh allows the reader to travel with him, from smoky tea stalls in south Kolkata to the narrow lanes of Murshidabad, where the damp breeze from the Bhagirathi mingles with the smell of simmering fish curry. Through these everyday conversations, he offers readers a synoptic view of the battleground.

The Bengal paradox, as Ghosh frames it, is that while people may protest, debate, and even despair, their votes often return to the familiar. Political change in the State does not arrive in waves; it moves, if at all, like a slow tide.

The timeliness of the book is simultaneously its strength and its weakness. Being written so close to the moment it seeks to capture, *Battleground Bengal* is more attuned to immediate political questions than to the deeper historical sediment that undergirds them.

Lights, camera, Kongu Nadu

Perumal Murugan’s book blends memoir and ethnography, capturing cinema’s enduring influence on Tamil society

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Kongu Nadu or the Kongu region of Tamil Nadu, comprising Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Erode, Karur, Namakkal, and Salem, long remained a stronghold of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK). Perumal Murugan’s *The Land and the Shadows*, translated from the Tamil by Gita Subramanian, brings together two of his works, *Nizhal Mutrathu Ninaivugal* and *Nilamum Nizhalum*, to offer valuable insights into the M.G. Ramachandran (known as MGR) phenomenon from the 1950s

to the 1970s.

Murugan, who was compelled to work in a soda shop run by his father at a touring talkies theatre, known as *kottaiyee* in the Tamil, and who went from village to village putting up posters for new film releases, happened to cultivate a taste for reading along the way. He went on to become a college teacher and a renowned novelist. The conditions in which he lived would have scarcely allowed space for intellectual pursuits, let alone sustained schooling. Yet the richness of his experiences and the vivid characters among whom he lived provided rich material for his literary pursuits.

Although grounded in the



Supporters of actor-turned-politician Vijay’s party Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam in Delhi. (GETTY IMAGES)

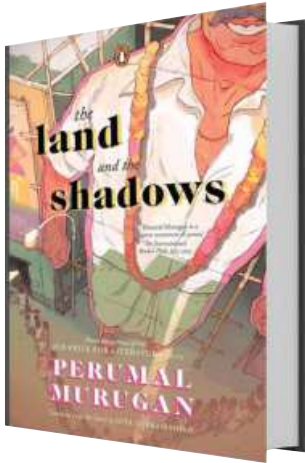
author’s formative years, the book serves as a microcosm of the wider Kongu region. It reflects a society that came under the spell of MGR, the film star-turned-politician and founder of the AIADMK. The work is not merely a memoir but also an ethnographic study, offering insights into the enduring influence of

cinema on Tamil society. This phenomenon is seen lately in the frenzy surrounding the political entry and victory of actor Vijay in the 2026 Assembly elections.

An incident narrated by Murugan speaks volumes about the MGR craze. Along with his friend Karuvayan, he went to a village at an

old man’s invitation to put up posters for *Padakotti*, an MGR starrer that had been released nearly a decade earlier. Yet the entire village, including women, assembled to see them. “You should see Saroja Devi in the film. She is like a parrot,” Murugan recalls a woman saying, while noting that it is difficult to identify the reasons behind the popularity of MGR.

He also compares MGR’s films



The Land and the Shadows
Perumal Murugan, trs Gita Subramanian
Hamish Hamilton
₹799

with those of another great actor, Sivaji Ganesan. A woman complains that Sivaji’s films made audiences cry. She says she is angry that in *Nichaya Thamboolam* (1962), his character suspects his wife of being unfaithful. MGR’s films, by contrast, never created such distressing situations.

The real-life characters in the book – Burmakaran, operator Rajendran, the theatre owner, and even the screening of *sami padam* (a euphemism for erotic cinema) – stay with the reader.

The closure of the theatre and its impact on Murugan’s father, who ran the soda shop as his sole livelihood, is a quiet tragedy. After waiting in vain for the theatre to reopen, his father sold the equipment used to make soda. “There is just fermented water in the pot. We have sieved all the rice in it, yet we continue searching for a few grains of cooked rice,” Murugan recalls his father saying about life. He would have been content if he could find even a single grain. He died a year after the theatre’s closure.

While the book reveals a world largely unfamiliar to the current generation of readers, the translation sometimes falls short of capturing the pain of the writer.

Swati Thivagarajan

In the mid-1980s, when I was a teenager, I saw something on Doordarshan that completely mesmerised me. It was David Attenborough's 13-part series, *Life on Earth*. From the first episode, 'The Infinite Variety', to the last, 'The Compulsive Communicators', it changed my life. It inspired me to become a conservation journalist, create my show *Born Wild*, and continue my work in ocean conservation. It left me with a lasting sense of wonder and curiosity about the natural world.

I was also lucky enough to meet and interview Attenborough twice. The first time was a brief 10-minute interaction; the second, an entire rainy afternoon at his home in Richmond, Surrey. After years of watching him on screen, listening to his voice, reading all his books and watching him become a global hero, I was prepared for the meetings to be formal. I thought I would have to deal with an entourage and that the interview would be monitored. But it was simply the man himself, in all his charm and humility.

The first time we met, he helped me set up my equipment, even though I was perfectly capable of doing it myself. He said he couldn't sit by while a young woman lifted heavy gear. Old-fashioned maybe, but undeniably charming. He was nearly 80 then. The second time, about a decade later, I had to plead with him to sit down after he helped me move a heavy table. I didn't want the infamy of being the journalist who injured Attenborough.

A life devoted

After the interview, he insisted I stay a while longer. He showed me fossils and bones from his collection, asking me to guess what they were – and, luckily, I got 8 out of 10 right. I share

his curiosity about ancient bones. He told me that one of his greatest childhood passions was fossil hunting, and he described the thrill of discovering them. It feels fitting that a dinosaur – *Attenborosaurus conybeari*, a Jurassic marine reptile – is named after him.

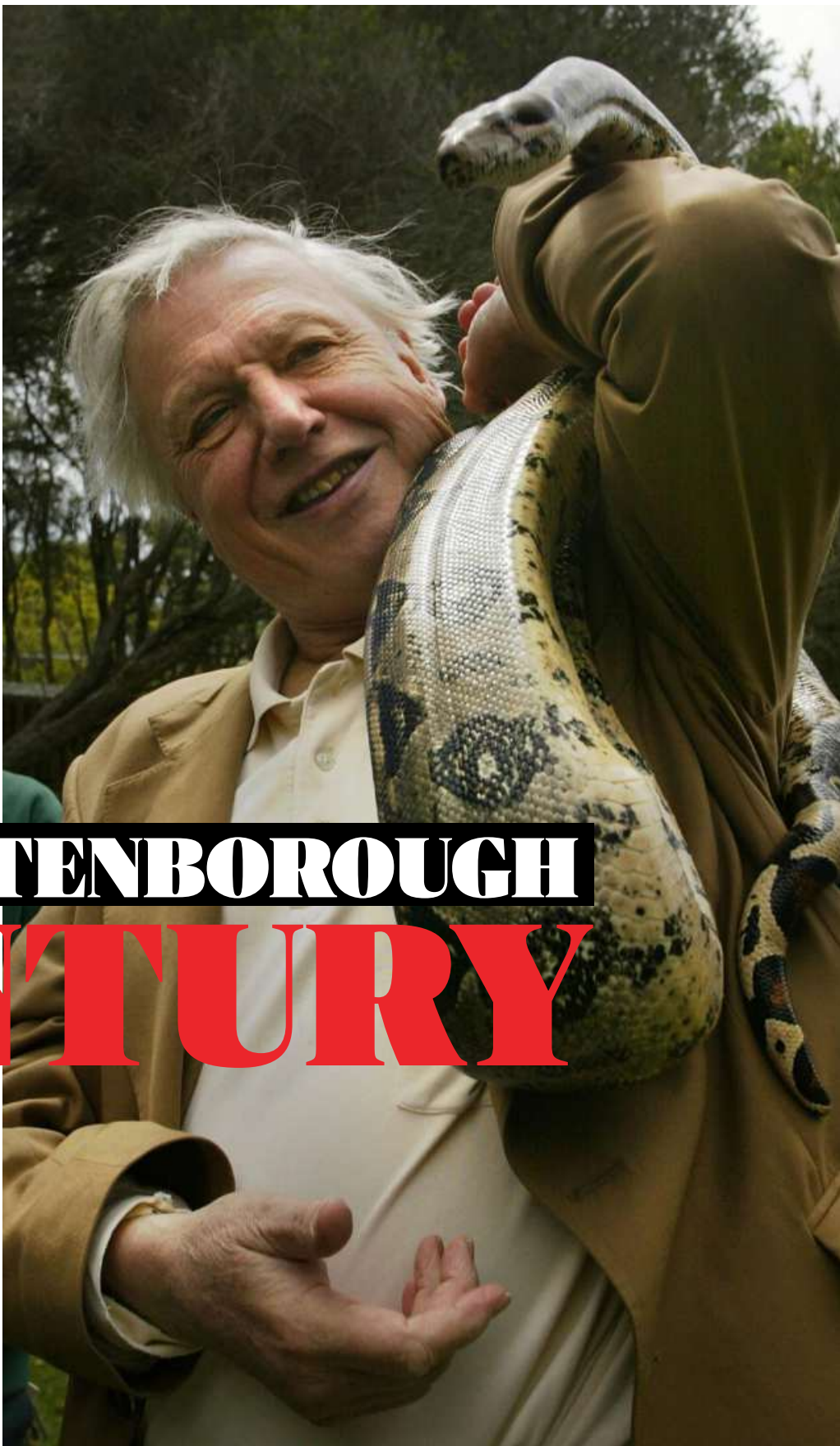
When I left, he stood at his gate in the rain, waving goodbye until our car turned onto the road.

After I returned to India, I sent him a short thank-you note. He doesn't use email, so I posted it – and received a prompt handwritten reply. He didn't need to, but that's who he is. Many colleagues who've met or worked with him describe the same graciousness and charm.

It's been argued, and not without reason, that his work could have carried a stronger conservation message, and that some of his programmes may have lulled viewers into thinking the natural world is untroubled. But his passion

THE ATTENBOROUGH CENTURY

A documentary filmmaker on how the broadcaster and historian inspired her to pursue a career in conservation and storytelling



David Attenborough carries a python at Sydney's Taronga Zoo, 2003. (GETTY IMAGES)

was to reveal awe and wonder, to help us see the miracle of the living planet so that we might come to care for it. In his ninth decade, he did become far more vocal about the threats facing the planet, and the solutions.

But what cannot be disputed is that his life has been devoted to nature. Generations of scientists, conservationists, artists, presenters and filmmakers, myself included, have been inspired by him to pursue what we do. That is just one part of his enduring legacy.

Heed his message

A little-known "fun" fact about him is that he's absolutely petrified of rats. A man who has handled poisonous spiders, snakes and dangerous predators simply cannot deal with rats. He told me that during a shoot in Rajasthan, a visit to the famous rat temple in Bikaner freaked him out – even challenging his belief that all animals deserve to be loved.

As he turns 100, he has just finished narrating and presenting a film on gorillas and remains busy with other projects. His core message now is one the world would do well to heed: "If working apart, we are a force powerful enough to destabilise our planet, surely working together we are powerful enough to save it."

For a man who has lived to see more than a thousand full moons, we can only hope he sees a thousand more – in a world that needs his voice more than ever.

The writer is a nature storyteller and filmmaker for the *Sea Change Project* and the author of *Born Wild* (2017).



Neelam Sanjiva Reddy

Anyone who writes about biodiversity today cannot ignore David Attenborough's work as a naturalist, author and television host. What has influenced me most is the way in which he presents science, particularly biology, as an act of storytelling. When I was researching and writing my recent book, *The Cobra's Gaze: Exploring India's Wild Heritage*, his approach to wildlife and wild places was certainly an inspiration. Without anthropomorphising the species he describes, Attenborough is able to narrate a compelling tale that captures a viewer's imagination and conveys a sense of wonder for all forms of life on this planet.

STEEPHEN ALTER
Author

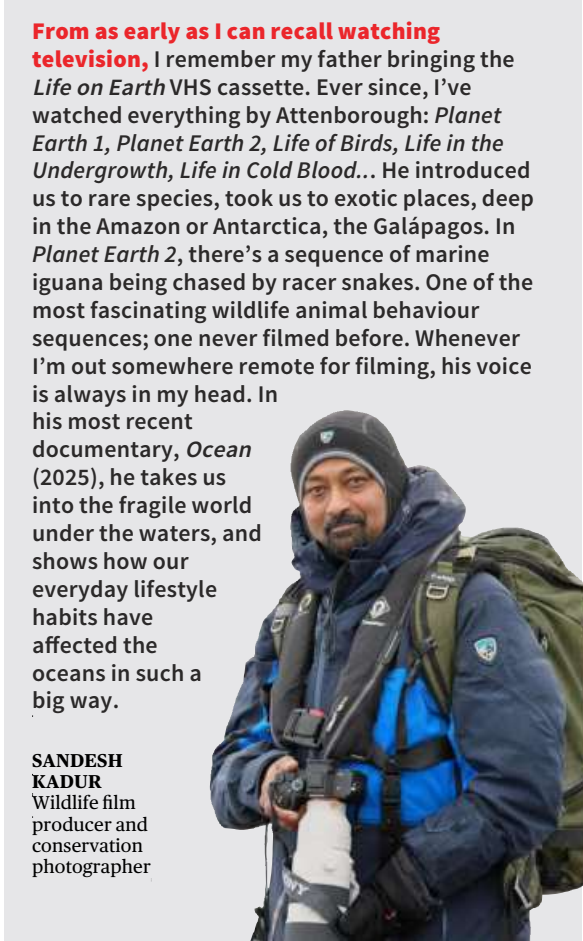
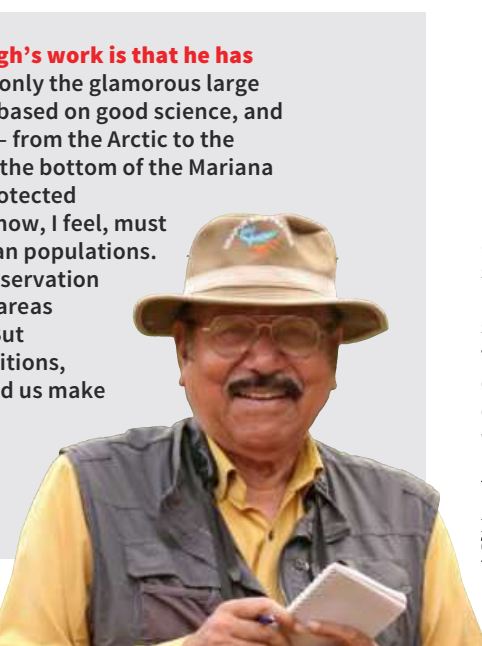
What is amazing about Attenborough's work is that he has covered almost all the species, not only the glamorous large vertebrates. His presentations were based on good science, and he covered almost the whole world – from the Arctic to the Antarctic and from the Himalayas to the bottom of the Mariana Trench. While his work celebrates protected wilderness, the global conservation now, I feel, must include negotiating with dense human populations. In India, we have to find our own conservation model because there are hardly any areas where there is no human presence. But interestingly in our country, our traditions, culture and religions have also helped us make room for wildlife.

ASAD RAHMANI
Ornithologist and former director of Bombay Natural History Society



In 2005, I had the honour of receiving a Whitley Fund for Nature award for establishing the Agumbe Rainforest Research Station in South India. And the other honour was the chance to meet and informally chat with Sir David. I had a million questions, and I remember his question to me, "I'm not comfortable with venomous snakes, and I wonder how you can be so casual with king cobras; they seem so alien, how do you get across to them?" I stumbled through what I thought was an intelligent response and we had an enjoyable chat about rainforests. Aside from being awestruck by the incredible wildlife programmes he has hosted over the decades, I couldn't resist asking him about the ultimate comedy show *Monty Python's Flying Circus*, which he commissioned for BBC Two in 1969. He said, "Yes, people were looking for something wacky and there it was."

ROMULUS WHITTAKER
Herpetologist and conservationist



SANDESH KADUR
Wildlife film producer and conservation photographer



David Attenborough's comments on reducing population in what he described as 'Asia and Africa' appeared careless and tone deaf. As he calls for nuance in the way we look at a creature, we need a similar nuance for the places that host many of these creatures: the developing world. Having said that, Attenborough's persistent work on creating appreciation for biodiversity – including wildlife that is seen as odd, venomous, slimy, ugly – is pathbreaking. He asks only for your attention as he tells you why something unloved is worth valuing, even loving, and this in a way reflects some of the modern jurisprudence debates around the Rights of Nature movement, which call for a full acceptance of an animal or natural feature, with all its bristles, characteristics, and its inalienable right to thrive.

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NEHA SINHA
Conservation biologist and author of *Wild Capital*

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Milan Design Week is often framed as a series of fairs and events. But after years of attending, I've come to see it as a series of encounters. Beyond schedules and spectacles, it offers the freedom to move through courtyards, industrial spaces and private interiors, each revealing a different way of thinking about design as part of a larger cultural and material dialogue.

Since Salone del Mobile began in the 1960s the furniture trade fair is one part of the design week, which includes the Fuorisalone – a series of citywide exhibitions and events), every spring Milan has become charged with energy and a shared vision for design's future. Few trade events shape the spirit of a city quite so profoundly.

This year showed a notable shift towards restraint, allowing materials to speak more directly and objects to derive meaning through their making. A recurring theme was also the growing intersection of cross-border collaboration. At a dinner, I was seated across noted French designer Philippe Starck, who was wonderfully entertaining and irreverent, and spoke about his real estate project in India. The next morning, over breakfast, Lebanese designer Elie Saab mentioned he, too, had a real estate project in India. The design week begins and



MILAN DESIGN WEEK WITH VIKRAM GOYAL

From experimental design at Alcovia to Gucci Memoria's tapestries, and even a quirky Caviar Silverware collection, the latest edition offered perspective and pause

ends with its people: conversations, shared explorations and unexpected meetings around craft, materiality and form. Below are the works and ideas that stayed with me most.

Alcovia
It remains one of the most vital platforms for emerging and experimental design, its often raw and expansive settings always amplifying discovery. Spread across the Baggio military hospital and the modernist Villa Pestarini (designed by the master of rationalism, Franco Albini), a standout was the Mexico-based Sten Studio's installation within an abandoned chapel in the hospital, where sculptural forms staged as a wedding

invited reflection on permanence and ritual.

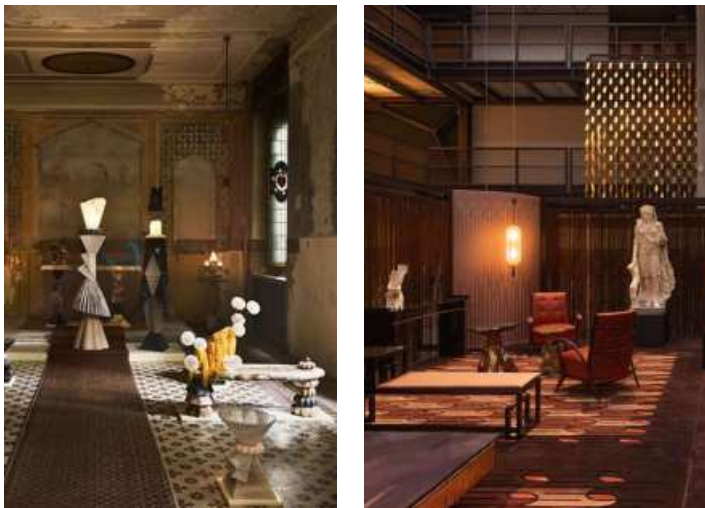
Shakti Design Residency
Also at Alcovia, the Shakti Design Residency, an initiative I have been involved with since inception, presented its second cohort. What distinguishes Shakti is its methodology: craft is approached as a living practice shaped by dialogue and philosophy. Rooted in the Japanese concept of *sukima*, the subtle intervals or spaces between forms, my own studio's collaboration with New York-based designer and architect Rodolfo Agrella resulted in *Natyam*, a modular hammered brass screen exploring movement and surface. Other interesting



collaborations included the cane structures developed with the Heirloom Naga Centre and Klove Studio's glass works.

Nilufar Depot
Among the most striking presentations of the week

(Clockwise from left) Jaipur Rugs x Kengo Kuma; Uzbek bread stamps; the Garden Pavilion, a deconstructed yurt created by Kulapat Yantrasast at *When Apricots Blossom*; *Gucci Memoria*'s botanical installation; *Grand Hotel* at Nilufar Depot; Sten Studio's *The Wedding*; *Natyam* at Shakti Design Residency; and Vikram Goyal. (RAMONA BALABAN, TARAN WILKIU, ALEJANDRO RAMIREZ ORDOZCO, COURTESY ACDP AND GUCCI)



was gallerist Nina Yashar's *Grand Hotel* at Nilufar Depot, where I have exhibited for several years. Using the "hotel" as a narrative device, each room became a distinct environment layering vintage and contemporary works into immersive, lived spaces. Seeing our bronze *Bagh* mirrors and side tables integrated into this composition was especially gratifying.

Dimore Gallery
At Dimore Gallery, one of Europe's most creative product and interior design studios, the setting itself was unforgettable. Housed within a former bank, the descent into the lower-level vault became a dramatic encounter with objects – from vintage and contemporary sculptures to lighting – where retained architecture was reinterpreted into an

atmospheric experience. Dimore's distinctive scenography transformed the original bank into a space of creativity and glamour.

Jaipur Rugs x Kengo Kuma
On a sunny morning, we drove out of Milan to the Crespi Bonsai Museum to witness the cultural dialogue between Jaipur Rugs and Kengo Kuma for the *Sukima* collection. It was less a design exercise and more a thoughtful exchange between architecture, craft and philosophy. Rooted in the Japanese concept of *sukima*, the subtle intervals or spaces between forms, the collaboration translated architectural philosophy into tactile surface through geometric motifs.

When Apricots Blossom
Presented at the 18th-century palace Palazzo Citterio, *When*

Apricots Blossom was one of the more thoughtful exhibitions this year. Commissioned by Gayane Umerova, leading the Uzbekistan Art and Culture Development Foundation, it was curated by Kulapat Yantrasast – the dynamic architect responsible for revamping the National Museum in New Delhi.

The exhibition unfolded as a journey through three essential elements of daily life: textiles (a colourful tapestry on the palazzo's facade), food (replicas of bread stamps used for dough), and shelter (large architectural sculptures). It brought focus to the Aral Sea region and Karakalpakstan, areas that have undergone significant environmental transformation, yet continue to sustain rich cultural traditions.

Gucci and Buccellati
Luxury fashion houses also offered immersive narratives. *Gucci Memoria*, curated by creative director Demna at the 16th-century cloisters Chiostrì di San Simpliciano, reflected on the fashion house's 105-year history through 12 monumental tapestries. They traced key moments to Gucci's contemporary direction, positioning craftsmanship as a primary language.

The scenography also extended into a botanical installation – a gigantic courtyard full of seasonal flowers in shades of white, pink and deep magenta. Similarly, jewellery and silverware maison Buccellati's *Aquae Mirabiles* transformed craftsmanship into a luminous theatrical environment with their Caviar Silverware. Featuring a surface defined by microspheres (to create the appearance of caviar), the tableware collection emphasised precision and artistry. Light, sound and a collaboration with British artist Luke Edward Hall also introduced an almost poetic layer.

The writer is the founder of *Vikram Goyal Studio* and lifestyle brand *Viya*. His practice encompasses design, art and craft revival.

I don't quite understand the brouhaha over Nicobar. The most stupid debate ever. All triggered by that video put out by Rahul Gandhi. I'll be honest. I'm not an expert on the environment. I can't plant a tree to save my life (or the planet). I can't tell you why you shouldn't endanger a species that is clearly labelled 'endangered species'. I mean, if a basket is labelled 'dust bin', wouldn't you use it as a dust bin?

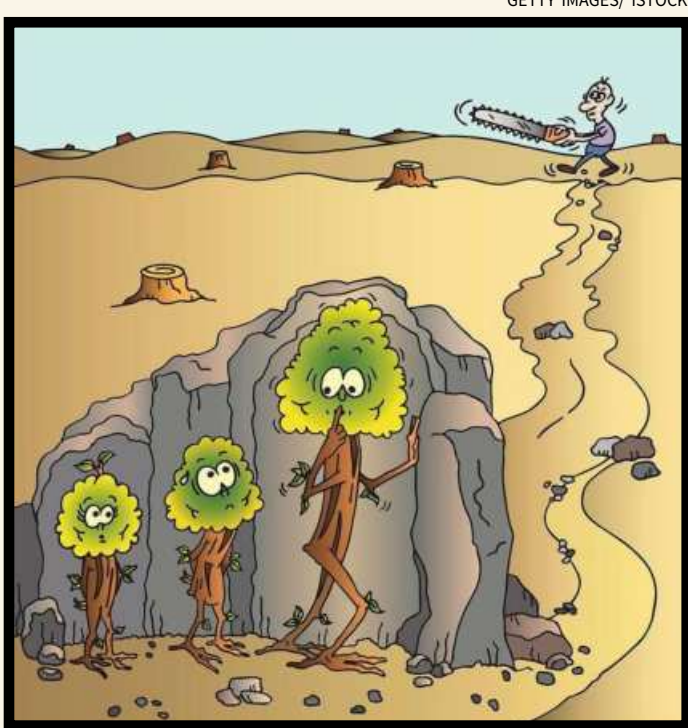
I am also no defence expert. I can't tell you how India can defend its enlarged military installations on Nicobar against China's DF-47 hypersonic missiles. But here's the thing: I don't need any expertise to defend the project. The intellectual prowess of a sea sponge is enough to conclude that Rahul – no matter what he says, and even before he says it – is wrong.

For instance, Rahul keeps repeating that the whole island is being gifted to a 'dani'. I don't know who or what a 'dani' is. But I'm certain it couldn't be worse than handing over the Indian Ocean to China, which will certainly happen if we don't cut down 1 crore trees on Nicobar.

Checkmate China

I don't know if there is any truth to the allegation coming from highly placed (WhatsApp) sources – that Rahul is a Chinese agent. I also don't know, and don't care, how much of Indian territory China grabbed in 2020. Don't ask me where our maritime power projection was hiding when America sank a visiting frigate in the Indian Ocean – an ocean named after you and my citizenship (until the NRC). But I know India's strategic national interest when I see it, and I've no doubt destroying 130 sq. km. of our most pristine tropical rainforest is the best option for India to checkmate China. It will discipline China by establishing our dominance over the Strait of Sundakka – a maritime chokepoint through which 89.99% of Chinese imports transit.

Incidentally, I was in Jingjiang last week for a two-day conference on the Indian Ocean. I could see Chinese officials literally quaking in their boots the moment I said 'Nicobar'. They began pleading with me to sway the Indian public opinion against this project. On the first day itself, during the buffet lunch, while I was busy hunting for Gobi Manchurian, a Chinese agent – an authentic Chinese Chinese agent, not Indian Chinese agent like Rahul – cornered me. "Can you do me a small favour?" he asked.



ALLEGEDLY

The Great Nicobar nuisance

Cut trees, save the nation: gifting the island to a dani can't be worse than handing over the Indian Ocean to China

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"I might," I said. "If you withdraw Chinese troops in Galwan to *status quo ante*, do *katti* with Pakistan, and make Hindi a compulsory subject in Chinese board till Class XII." "What is Chinese board?" "Forget it," I said. "What do you want?" "We Chinese are terrified of India controlling the Strait of Vaalakka," he said. "You mean the Strait of Sundakka?" "No, Vaalakka," he said. "Then I have nothing more to say to you," I said, walking away angrily. "Wait, I'm sorry, Mr. Sampath," he said. "We have

our own names for places, you know. Like we do for your Arunachal. I have to follow it or I'll lose my job."

"Fine," I said. "Be quick. Whatever you have to say."

Environmental destruction is national sport

"The Great Nicobar Island is a massive waste of prime real-estate. We want it to stay that way. If India's contractor-oligarchy-politician nexus turns this island into a 'natural' aircraft carrier that doubles up as Singapore-Hong Kong, it will pose an existential threat to us."

"You believe India will actually do it?"

"Well, we're aware you still don't know how to build a road that can withstand one monsoon. But we can't take any chances. So, please resist against this project, saying that it will ravage the environment, etc."

"I can't do that," I said. "Even if I did, it would only strengthen public support for it."

"Really?" The Chinese agent looked shocked.

"Absolutely," I said. "I am appalled that, with all your surveillance technology, your intelligence is so clueless as to think that highlighting environmental costs could make Indians drop a golden opportunity to destroy their greatest environmental assets! In India, the best guarantee that a project will go through is to stipulate that it must cut millions of trees, dismantle native communities, and exterminate endemic flora and fauna. Environmental destruction is our national sport, Sirji!"

"I am Sir Lee," he interjected. "Sir Lee has gone to the washroom."

"Just remember," I said.

"You have your String of Pearls, so we're building our own 'Pearl Harbour'!"

"Okay then," he shrugged.

"Trade will solve. Indian-Chini buy-buy."

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

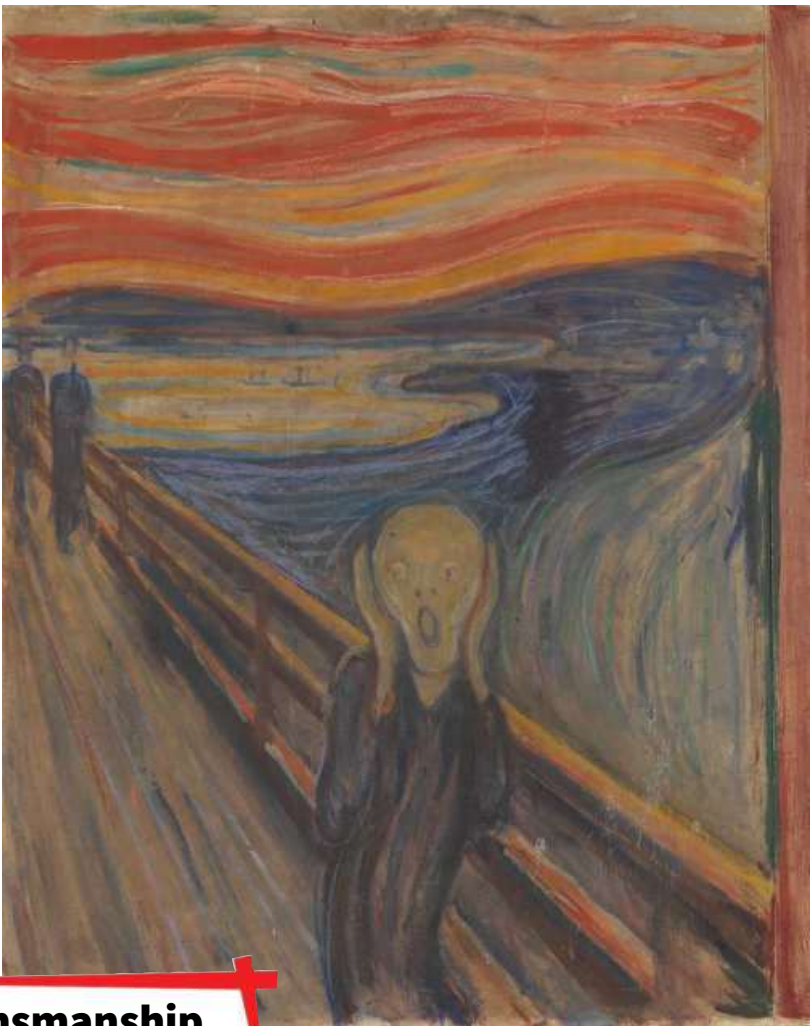
TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 30

MY PAIN IS BETTER THAN YOURS

Friends, what is this phenomenon of competitive misery?

Dear readers, how are you? It has been a few weeks since we last spoke. But so many things have happened since then. The news is just relentless. Is it not exhausting? Every single day, there is something or the other happening. Elections. Wars. Scandals. Sporting events. Social media kerfuffles. Entertainment industry headlines. I find it all very exhausting indeed. Back when I was but a small child of 6 or 7, my parents used to tell me to consume the news every day. Read the newspaper, they would say, it will make you a more knowledgeable person. It will help you be a mature human being. And so I would spend 30 minutes every day going through the morning newspaper, and later discuss current affairs with friends at school. And by current affairs, I mean Sachin Tendulkar, plane hijackings or assassinations. But those innocent childhood

days are behind us. Gone are the days when you could meet a friend for coffee or at the football ground, and someone would ask: "By the way, who is the Prime Minister of the United Kingdom?" And then all of you would look at each other. Then someone would say: "It is Ian Botham?" And you would all agree to move on to other topics. Mainly, Sachin Tendulkar. Sometimes, Raveena Tandon. But, these days, you can't even have a relaxing matcha latte without someone slapping you around the face with current affairs. So, what about the whole Strait of Hormuz thing, Sidin? Please leave me and my matcha latte alone. Which is all very bad enough. But today, I want to raise another issue



Painsmanship

that is plaguing mutual discourse in modern society. Namely, the inability to suffer anything alone. Let me explain. A few weeks ago, I met a friend for a beverage. I had just returned from the gym after some assorted exercises. Several Vande Bharats of pain were criss-crossing the rain network of muscles in my body. "Sorry if I seem uncomfortable," I told my friend, "but I just did some

Romanian deadlifts and my glutes are on fire." Readers, you tell me. What is the decent thing to do when someone shares a malaise with you? You sympathise, ask for more details, and then offer moral or other support, yes? Apparently, this trend died out in the 2010s. Nobody does this anymore. Instead, they try to compete with you on suffering. "Oh, your glutes are hurting? I just did a half-marathon on Sunday, and my shins are still hurting from all

Painsmanship
/ˈpeɪnzməˌnʃɪp/
noun
Definition: The competitive practice of responding to someone's complaint or expression of discomfort by immediately asserting that one has suffered something significantly worse, thereby hijacking the conversation and transforming shared sympathy into a contest of misery.
Related forms:
Painsman (noun): A person who practices painsmanship
Painsmanly (adjective): Displaying characteristics of painsmanship
Outpained (verb, past tense): To have been defeated in a painsmanship competition

lucky, and how they got even worse service on Gulf Air. Complain loudly that the traffic in Mumbai is unbearable, and someone will ask you to go and live in some other country instead of complaining. Friends, look. I understand. You also have a life full of inconveniences and disturbances. But please shut up and listen to mine, no? And if you are so obsessed with making yourself the centre of attention, then do the decent thing: go convince someone at a major national newspaper to give you a fortnightly column where you can write thinly veiled criticisms of your friends, spouses, children, etc. Meanwhile, I think it is very important that we come up with a word for this phenomenon of competitive misery. So that we can immediately name and shame such behaviour. And generate tremendous social sanction against such shenanigans. And that word is: painsmanship. **Example sentence:** "Priya complained about her two-hour commute through Bengaluru traffic, but Avisek's painsmanship was undefeated: 'Two hours? When I was your age, I walked 47 kilometres uphill, both ways, in the monsoon while carrying my grandmother on my shoulders.'" Have you been the victim of painsmanship recently? Did it really annoy you? Well, a lot of things annoyed me recently as well. Do you want to hear about them?



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

Bob Jones

Today's deal is from a match between a team from Denmark and a team from France. At the other table, the French West player chose to raise hearts at his first turn. North-South found their spade fit and played in the unhappy contract of four spades, down four. At this table, West chose to bid one spade, picking off the North-South spade fit. Three no trump was not such a happy

GOREN BRIDGE

Solving the problem

Neither vulnerable, East deals

contract either, but it was played by French star Catherine D'Ovidio, sitting South. D'Ovidio won the opening heart lead with her ace and assessed her chances. A successful spade finesse would give her two spade tricks and two hearts. She

would need five tricks from the diamond suit. Assuming East had the king of diamonds for the opening bid, it would have to be doubleton. She couldn't play the ace of diamonds and then play a low diamond from both hands, as she would have no entry back to

her hand for the king of hearts and to take the spade finesse. If she cashed the high heart, and took the spade finesse before playing on diamonds, the opponents would have enough winners to defeat her. She solved the problem neatly by leading a low diamond away from her ace and playing low from dummy. She still had the ace of diamonds as an entry for the king of hearts and the spade finesse. When the king of diamonds fell under the ace and the spade finesse worked, she had nine tricks. Beautifully done!

NORTH
♠ A Q 6 5
♥ Void
♦ Q 8 6 5 3 2
♣ Q 9 7

WEST
♠ K J 10 9
♥ 10 7 5
♦ J 10 4
♣ K 10 8

EAST
♠ 8
♥ Q J 9 8 6
♦ K 9
♣ A 6 5 4 3

SOUTH
♠ 7 4 3 2
♥ A K 4 3 2
♦ A 7
♣ J 2

The bidding:
EAST 1♥
SOUTH Pass
WEST 1♠
NORTH 2♦
EAST Pass
SOUTH 2♥
WEST 3♥
NORTH All pass

Opening lead: Seven of ♥

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

Spilling the tea on Tea



The phrase 'spill the tea' originated in Black drag culture from the late 1980s, where it was slang for gossip. GETTY IMAGES

Berty Ashley

On May 10, 1773, the Parliament of Great Britain passed an act to reduce taxes on tea and sell it directly to its colonies in North America. The ensuing protest led to the outbreak of the Revolutionary War in 1775, and ultimately to the American independence. What was the protest that took place in a harbour known as?

The phrase 'spill the tea' originated in Black drag culture in the late 20th century, where it meant gossip. One theory is that it evolved from 'spill the T'. What did the "T" stand for in that context?

During World War II, one country's crews suffered high casualties because they were

exposed while making tea outside their tanks. The army then introduced a specialised 'boiling vessel' (electric kettle) in all Centurion tanks and subsequent armoured vehicles. Which army ensured soldiers could make tea inside tanks?

Camellia sinensis, the tea plant, thrives in acidic soils and can accumulate relatively high levels of a particular element. This results in tea drinkers ingesting small amounts of it, though it is usually excreted by the body. What is this element, whose spelling differs between American and British English?

In this sport, athletes have access to drinking water during the race. However, British world champion Damon Hill, reportedly,

carried cold black tea so it would heat up during the race and give him a hot beverage. Which gruelling sport did he compete in?

These terms refer to the height of dining tables rather than their level of formality. One describes a classy social affair, a light meal served at a low table, while the other refers to a larger meal at a standard-height dining table. What are these two terms?

This sensation, experienced after drinking tea, is called astringency. It comes from tannins binding to lubricating saliva proteins, causing them to aggregate. What sensation is this?

The 1904 St. Louis World's Fair popularised several iconic foods, such as the ice cream cone,

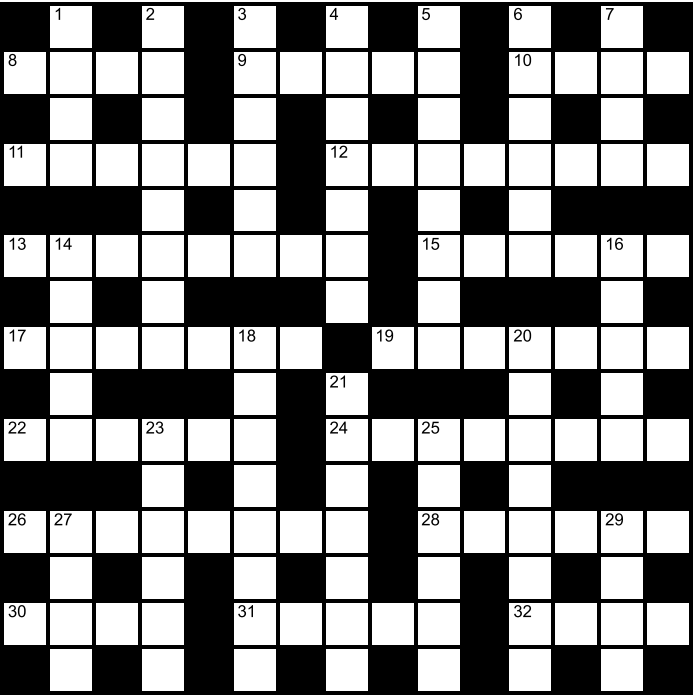
hot dogs, and cotton candy. Richard Blechynden, who was there to promote Indian teas, introduced a refreshing drink which became a national sensation. What did he promote to combat the summer heat?

Lapsang souchong is an aromatic Chinese tea known for its intense smoky flavour. It is smoke-dried over pinewood fire and is used as a black tea. Due to its flavour profile, with what alcoholic beverage is it usually compared to?

Around the world, the drink is referred to by some form of either 'tea' or 'chai'. Both originate from the Chinese word for the tea plant, but the divergence in pronunciation depends on how the tea was transported. Any country that got it via maritime trade shipping route calls it 'tea'. Countries that call it 'cha' got the drink through which route?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

THE SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 55 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
- 8 Central part in Orinoco region (4)
 - 9 Motorcyclist from Britain captures Eisenhower (5)
 - 10 Ontario church, at one time (4)
 - 11 Perhaps, bends and moves bowels (6)
 - 12 Teen vamp walks around side-walk (8)
 - 13 Perhaps, tax payer's a beast of burden, getting notice without extensive search for starters (8)
 - 15 Animal that may be ailing? (6)
 - 17 Each cut oozes a plant extract (7)
 - 19 Set up residence outside a city (7)
 - 22 Go and set right (6)
 - 24 Most unapproachable meteor destroyed by saint (8)
 - 26 A salutation, in absence of model, conveying assent (8)
 - 28 No aide goes around American lake (6)
 - 30 Attempt consuming egg in city (4)
 - 31 Magical creature that is following general (5)
 - 32 At all times, woman gets first right (4)
- Down**
- 1 Bishop getting bird's container (4)
 - 2 No seeker may produce paraffin (8)
 - 3 Sailor employs curses (6)
 - 4 Small processed fish for captain (7)
 - 5 Junior royal going around old Viscount's territory (8)
 - 6 Male in capital near port is a famous

- Field Marshal (6)
- 7 Read, "Dolt left Scotland" (4)
- 14 Minced steak and fish (5)
- 16 A salt creates aid for navigation (5)
- 18 That lady's ornaments? Maybe red, perhaps... (8)
- 20 Anchored decaying red teeth (8)
- 21 Doctor composed a song for legendary creatures (7)
- 23 In seaman's lingo, word conveying assent twice to get an animal (3-3)
- 25 Tied low, a colour from the traffic signal (6)
- 27 Dress made from some sugar beet (4)
- 29 Attracted actress Barrymore (4)

SOLUTION NO.54

C	O	P	P	S	O	T	S
E	A	V	E	S	D	R	O
L	A	Y	I	R	I	B	R
L	I	L	A	C	S	O	A
A	H	E	Y	R	P		
R	E	S	P	H	E	G	R
S	U	L	U	V	A	Y	
I	N	C	O	N	V	E	N
S	G	G	I	R	L	P	
H	A	L	C	O	N	R	I
A	A	D	E	H	R		
D	E	S	I	C	A	T	E
O	S	A	L	F	E	R	M
W	R	E	A	K	O	V	E
Y	S	E	O	R	E	N	S



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

A saviour from
nowhere

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For hours, the poor kitten had been mewling for help in the backyard of the neighbouring office building. Though people moved in and out, she remained unattended. Hours passed, and the day went by; the high-pitched cries gradually faded into a feeble mew. She might have been hurt or hungry; that poor little creature silently waited for a helping hand to comfort her. That backyard itself was a remnant of yesteryear, filled with broken and abandoned furniture among piles of junk, making it nearly impossible for anyone to enter.

One day, a man came to her rescue. The piles of junk and those hurdles did not deter him from reaching the kitten. The kitten was black, fragile, tiny, barely a few weeks old, and hardly surviving. Her eyes were infected, barely able to open, and she was severely wounded, possibly from any previous life-threatening attacks by other animals.

His warm hands tenderly lifted her from the ground and nursed her back to health. He tended those wounds and ensured she had a warm, safe space to recover. After a few courses of medication, her little eyes were wide open, gleaming with heartfelt gratitude towards him. He named her Tara, meaning a star, a tiny shining star in the dark world. He had the option to stay at home and enjoy his retirement life peacefully, but instead, he made sure to visit two or three times every day with food and medicine. For Tara, he became her entire world, her saviour, her protector, and her caretaker. Every time, Tara silently waited in her new cardboard shelter adorned with a customised cushion, anticipating his arrival.

This story is indeed a testament to the miraculous life we are living and the power of compassion in our everyday lives. She found warmth, care, and love because someone selflessly chose to act. The way Mother Nature created all living beings to help and protect one another is both exquisite and intriguing. From the bond they share, we are reminded that compassion and love are two powerful tools capable of healing and making this world a kinder, better place to live.

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He sits beside her husband's body, her face still and unreadable. Not because she feels nothing, but because the grief is too immense for words. The photograph, taken after the Pahalgam terrorist ambush, captures a moment that many across the country will not easily forget.

It is not a graphic image. There is no spectacle in it. Yet it is difficult to look away. In that quiet moment, the photograph captures something deeper than shock. It reveals the human weight of loss.

Documenting tragedies
Sometimes a single photograph comes to define how a nation remembers its tragedies. Long after headlines fade and details blur, the image remains.

Across decades of modern Indian history, certain images have done exactly that.

In 1984, the country was confronted with one of the most haunting photographs from the Bhopal gas tragedy. Shot by photojournalist Pablo Bartholomew, the image showed a child partially buried in the soil, a tiny hand raised as if frozen in a final gesture. The photograph did not simply document death. It exposed the scale of negligence and the human cost of industrial failure.

A few years earlier, another set of images had shocked the nation. In Bhagalpur, photographs emerged of undertrial prisoners with bandaged eyes after acid had been poured into their sockets during what came to be known as the Bhagalpur blindings. The images were stark evidence of brutality carried out by those meant to uphold the law. Public outrage followed, demonstrating how photographs can force uncomfortable truths into public conscience.

The year 1984 brought yet another rupture. After the assassination of Indira Gandhi, the anti-Sikh riots tore through Delhi and other cities. Among the many images from that period, one photograph of a Sikh father shielding his young son from a mob came to symbolise the terror and betrayal felt by an entire community. It was not only an image of violence. It reflected the breakdown of trust between citizens and the state.

Nearly two decades later, a similarly powerful image emerged during the Gujarat riots of 2002. The photograph of Qutubuddin Ansari, hands folded and eyes filled with fear as he pleaded for his life, travelled across the country. It became a stark reminder of how quickly ordinary neighbourhoods can descend into hatred and fear.

If communal violence produced faces of betrayal, terrorism produced portraits of innocence shattered. In 1993, the coordinated bomb blasts across Mumbai stunned the country. Among the images that circulated widely was that of a dazed, bloodied man standing amid shattered glass and debris near the Air India building. The photograph captured the stunned disbelief of a city confronting large-scale terror for the first time.

Fifteen years later, the 26/11 attacks



When grief has a face
Certain photographs come to define how
India remembers its darkest moments

produced images that remain etched in public memory. One showed Ajmal Kasab walking through a railway station with a rifle in hand. Another showed the iconic dome of the Taj Mahal Palace Hotel engulfed in flames. Together, these images captured both the brutality of the attack and the resilience of the city that endured it.

Even tragedies beyond India's borders sometimes resonate deeply at home. During the Brussels airport bombing in 2016, the photograph of injured Indian flight attendant Nidhi Chaphekar sitting dazed on a bench travelled across the world. Her torn uniform and distant gaze transformed a distant event into something painfully personal for many Indians.

War, too, leaves behind images that define its emotional legacy. During the Kargil War, photographs of fallen soldiers returning home stirred deep national sentiment. The image of the coffin of Captain Vikram Batra carried by fellow soldiers was one such moment. It was not about strategy or victory. It was about sacrifice and the quiet dignity of loss.

In more recent years, the COVID-19 pandemic produced its own gallery of unforgettable images. Funeral pyres burning in open grounds, daughters in protective suits holding dying parents, migrant workers walking

barefoot across highways with children in their arms. These photographs captured not only a public health crisis but also the inequalities and vulnerabilities laid bare by it.

Some images transcend national boundaries altogether. The photograph of Phan Thi Kim Phuc running in agony after a napalm attack during the Vietnam War remains one of the most powerful images of war ever taken. Like the haunting human shadows left behind by the atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, it reminds us that the scars of violence endure long after the moment itself has passed.

Unfiltered humanity
What unites these photographs is their unfiltered humanity. They were not staged or composed for effect. They simply captured a moment when truth revealed itself.

And that is why they endure.

Such images speak for those who never had the chance to tell their own stories. They do not analyse or explain. Instead, they compel us to pause and remember.

News moves quickly. Memory does not. The photograph of that grieving woman may endure long after the headlines fade, reminding us of the human cost behind every tragedy.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Chettinad's revival is at a critical juncture. ('Chettinad's paradox of fame'; May 3) While heritage mansions are dismantled for timber and tile, adaptive reuse offers a sustainable alternative. Restoring homes as homestays, museums and community spaces can generate livelihoods and preserve craftsmanship. Stronger heritage laws, incentives for conservation, skill training and responsible tourism are vital to position Chettinad as a model of living heritage.

N.S. Reddy

The real threat to these mansions is not neglect alone but the absence of a legal framework that distinguishes between legitimate restoration and outright dismantling for parts. State authorities should consider a graded listing of Chettinad structures, restrict the export of architectural elements and offer meaningful tax relief to families that maintain their homes.

A. Myilsami

These heritage homes are not merely private residences but repositories of a rich cultural and economic past. As the article notes, migration, high maintenance costs and the absence of structured conservation efforts have left several of these iconic structures vulnerable. Addressing this requires coordinated action from both the government and civil society. Encouraging responsible tourism and community participation would further strengthen these efforts.

Muhammed Kollapparamban



MORE ON THE WEB
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Bonding with nature in Munnar

One of Kerala's few remaining wildlife-rich 'green lungs'

George Netto

Nature and poetry

Nature has taken early retirement and poets are left staring at their screens

Chanchala Borah

The problem of plenty

When gratification is instantaneous and constant, the capacity to derive joy from simple experiences diminishes

Manda Venkata Apparao

Beyond the textbook

A case for practical robotics in schools

K.L.Vaishnavi

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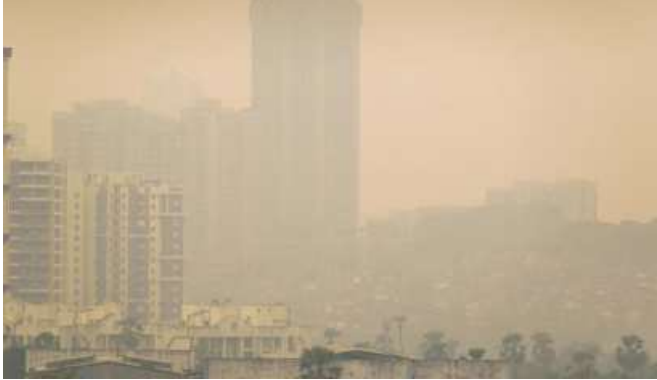
“The sky is blue!” I shout to no one in particular. I can’t contain my joy as I look out of the window. The sky, just as we learnt in school, is blue, finally. The last time I saw a sky this blue was when my neighbour’s child in primary school proudly flaunted her school drawing. Otherwise, the skies I know, of late in Mumbai, have been only in shades of grey, off white, sometimes a light brown.

To record this rare occurrence, I take several pictures and share them in my family group. Just photos of plain blue sky. But it hardly evokes the reaction I expect. Nobody seems to be impressed. So I add a line, “Look. The sky is blue!”, with exclamation points for emphasis. Again, silence, except for a cousin’s dry comment: “And the grass is green.” That’s when it dawns on me that 90% of the members in my group live where the sky has somehow still managed to stay blue.

I suddenly realise how much I had taken it for

For a breath of
rare fresh air

In most cities, the air hangs heavy with
pollutants, weighing on the lungs



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

granted earlier and how rare this has become – especially in a city such as Mumbai that feels perpetually a work in progress; where drilling and hammering is the all-day background score to the dance of everyday life, and for some reason, everyone is constantly redoing their homes and offices. Temporary inconvenience

has quietly become permanent. In the race to improve quality of life, air quality has become collateral damage.

Before AQI became a thing, my informal tool for measuring air quality was visibility – specifically whether my friend’s apartment across the street had disappeared for the day.

“We can’t go out for a walk today”, I would say. “I can’t see Anjali’s apartment properly.” This was how I gauged the air.

Not going out for a walk posed a problem. My Vitamin D levels were low and the doctor had advised sun exposure along with supplements. But I wasn’t ready to risk my lung health – the city’s polluted air being equivalent to smoking six to 10 cigarettes per day – for sunlight. So the solution was a walk in the park, wearing an N95 mask.

New normal

Since most people have accepted bad air quality as the new normal with no mandate for wearing masks, I am often the only one in the park wearing a mask – which draws a few side-glances and smirks. It hardly matters for life is no longer what I had envisioned it to be. For instance, the only PMs I knew of earlier were Post Meridien (yes, 4 p.m.) and Prime Minister. Now, PM 2.5 and PM 10 are part of my daily life.

That morning, with the sky brilliant and blue, with my friend’s apartment clearly visible, I ventured out for my walk mask-less. The first

thing that hit me was the air itself. It smelled normal, fresh, like how air is supposed to smell. Now, I have an acute sense of smell. Not exactly an advantage in a city such as Mumbai. My nose can detect a gas leak three floors up, a rainstorm approaching, a masala fry in the local dhaba, the agarbathi in the nearby apartment, and most unfortunately, dirty air.

That day, all that my nose picked up was the scent of the sea breeze, a faint whiff of cardamom from the cutting chai stall and an unknown perfume from someone walking past me. I was elated and if I could bottle that air and share it with my group, I would have done so. After a long long time, I enjoyed a walk that left me “soothed and healed, with my senses put in order”. I lingered a little longer than usual, taking it all in. For you never know when the sky will turn blue again, the air will be pure again. Experts ascribe the blue sky to a shift in weather. Officials say it’s because they shut down a thousand construction sites. But I think, the sky was just feeling blue and finally decided to let us know.

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